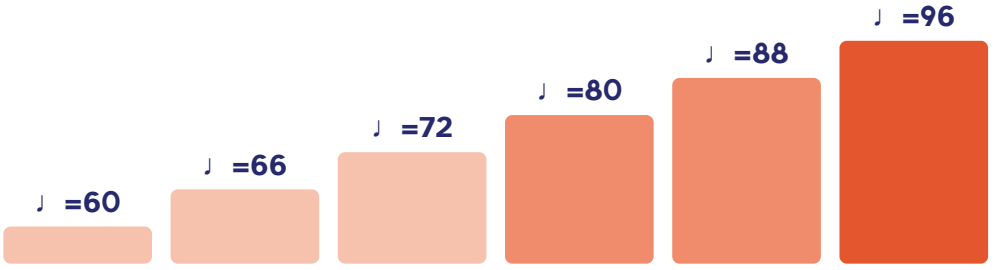
PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 2

Practising well

Practice is not playing a piece again and again from the top. It is fixing the hard bits, slowly and correctly, then joining them back together.

THE SECRET

Slow, small, and correct; then a little faster; then join the pieces.



three correct times at one speed, then one step up

Slow and correct, one step at a time

A fifteen-minute plan

TIME	WHAT YOU DO
2 min	warm up: a scale or five-finger exercise
5 min	the hardest bars, slowly, hands separately
5 min	join the bars, hands together, still slow
3 min	play the whole section; mark what slipped

Four tools

TOOL	HOW
small chunks	one bar, or two, plus the first note of the next
hands separately	each hand alone until it is easy, then together
slow, then faster	the metronome ladder: three correct times, then one notch up
count aloud	say the beats: it keeps the rhythm honest

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER
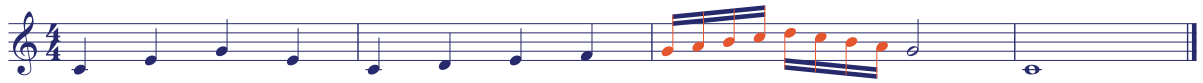
Practise in rhythms

For a run of even quavers, play it long–short, then short–long, slowly. When you go back to even notes, the run is suddenly easier: every note has been the “long” one.

PART VIII · PLAYING AND LISTENING · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which bar first?



1. **Play it through once.** Where did it slip?
2. **The semiquavers** in bar 3: hardest?
3. **Start there**, slowly.

Bar 3, the semiquavers: practise the **hardest bar first**, slowly, then join bars 2–4.

EXAMPLE 2

When do you speed up?

♩ =60: right, right, wrong ?

1. **How many correct** in a row do you need?
2. **After a mistake**, start counting again.
3. **Then** one notch up.

Not yet: three **correct** in a row at 60, then try 66.

GAME

Good habit or not?

1	2
from the top	hardest first
3	4
faster to fix	slow, correct

Which help?

Answer: 2 and 4 help; 1 and 3 waste time.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

60 → 66 → 72

Climb the ladder.

Pick one hard bar. Play it three times correctly at a slow speed, then one notch faster. Stop when it slips twice.

HOW TO

Keep a practice log

1. **Write the date** and what you practised.
2. **Note one thing** that got better and one that did not.
3. **Start tomorrow** with the one that did not.

THINK OF IT Practice is like building a wall: lay each brick straight and the wall stands on its own.

TRAP

- × Practising mistakes: playing fast and wrong teaches your fingers the wrong notes.
- × Only playing what you already know: spend most time on the hard bits.

SEE ALSO

Speed words p. 79 · Fingering p. 160

PRACTISE IT

Online: Metronome · Practice log